Nanak—in solidarity with him. The SAD's core *panthic* cadre in these seats are split among rivals Congress, Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and BJP. The BJP has fielded three candidates with Akali backgrounds—Manpreet Badal (Gidderbaha), Ravikaran Kahlon (Dera Baba Nanak) and Sohan Singh Thandal (Chabbewal). The AAP has picked up ex-SAD man Hardeep Singh Dimpy Dhillon for Gidderbaha. Even so, the biggest threat to the SAD today is Sikh radicals capturing their space. In the Lok Sabha polls, Amritpal Singh and another radical, Sarabjeet Khalsa in Faridkot, had won big. Ex-MP and pro-Khalistan leader Simranjit Singh Mann has also fielded his grandson, Govind Singh Sandhu, from the fourth seat, Barnala.

SUKHBIR CAN'T DO ANY POLITICAL ACTIVITY TILL HE DOES *TANKHA* (PUNISHMENT), WHICH AKAL TAKHT IS YET TO ANNOUNCE. THE DELAY IS NOT HELPING AT ALL

In another development, on November 12, the apex court asked the Bhagwant Mann-led AAP government in Punjab not to waiti for the fresh delimitation exercise and finalise the poll schedule for five municipal corporations and 42 municipal councils/ nagar panchayats within 15 days. The SAD can't afford to miss the local body polls too.

The Akali Dal hit a political nadir in the Lok Sabha polls after 11 of 13 party candidates lost their deposit; only Sukhbir's wife Harsimrat Badal managed to win, in Bathinda. In the 117-seat assembly, it had only three MLAs, out of which Sukhwinder Sukhi has switched to AAP, Manpreet Ayali has refused to participate in party activities as long as Sukhbir is at the helm, and the third, Ganieve Kaur Majithia (wife of Harsimrat's brother Bikramjit), is a political novice. Needless to say, the Akali Dal finds itself at the brink and will need some strong direction and verve to pull itself back. ■



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

CENTRAL FIGURE
From left, BJP general secretary Sunil Bansal, party leader Suvendu Adhikari, Union home minister Amit Shah and Bengal BJP chief Sukanta Majumdar at the launch of the membership drive in Kolkata, Oct. 27

WEST BENGAL

BJP'S BENGAL SLIDE

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

BJP national general secretary Sunil Bansal warned leaders of the party's Bengal unit of his *kukhyat* (infamous) side at an online meeting recently. The party's minder for the state tore into his colleagues, shocked by their abysmal performance in the ongoing membership drive that was launched by Union home minister Amit Shah in the state on October 26. The central leadership had fixed a total target of 10 million members for West Bengal; till November 7, only 450,000 persons had completed the process of becoming a BJP member, many of them being renewal of memberships. Bansal's ire was targeted at district presidents whom he threatened to remove from their posts if they continue to under-perform. "I was *kukhyat* in Uttar Pradesh for brutally removing people. I will do the same here if I don't see results. No *sifarish* (application) from any *bhaisaab*